DISTANCE MAKES THE HEART GROW FONDER, THEY SAY. For Bollywood's 'King' Khan, his hiatus from the big screen lasted over four long years. Too long, you'd think, for a man in his mid-50s who's invested in mining himself from a mirror paused in springtime. So when he did announce his return—with a chiselled physique, man bun swagger, gruff voice, the works—profuse love from fans was not entirely unanticipated. What nobody expected, though, was that this hungry fanhood would end up unleashing a full-blown box-office tsunami. *Pathaan*, coming after a sorry washout like *Zero* (2018) had lowered the standard of even a flop as defined in the Shah Rukh Khan dictionary, went on to become the highest-earning Hindi film of all time in India: a Rs 560 crore-plus colossus, to be precise. Worldwide, it netted over Rs 1,000 crore. In doing all this, *Pathaan* almost single-handedly pulled Bollywood and single-screen cinemas in the Hindi belt out of the long lull Covid-19 left behind, while cementing Khan's credentials as arguably the biggest of contemporary Indian stars. But this was only the beginning. As he warned us in the film, Pathaan... "*zinda hai*". More was to come.

A salt-and-pepper Shah Rukh Khan? Here was the very picture of Bollywood juvenescence being unafraid to embrace his age



WINNING STREAK

- ***Pathaan*, released in January 2023, set several box office records, registering the highest opening day, highest single day and highest opening weekend for a Hindi film in India. It eventually became the highest-grossing Hindi film of all time in India—until *Jawan* came**
- **When Khan signed on Atlee for *Jawan*, it was the first Hindi film for the then 34-year-old director**
- ***Jawan* is the ninth film in which Khan plays a double role. He has previously essayed double roles in *English Babu Desi Mem*, *Karan Arjun*, *Duplicate*, *Paheli*, *Don*, *Om Shanti Om*, *Ra.One*, and *Fan***

Six months later, Khan shook a leg to 'Zinda Banda', the first song to promote his home production, *Jawan*. An upright jailer moonlighting as a vigilante hero—leading an army of six women, fighting for the common civilian, sickened by society's ills and injustices and taunting corrupt politicians with his tricks—struck such a nerve with Indians that *Jawan* went on to surpass even *Pathaan*'s collections, replacing it as the highest-grossing Hindi film ever domestically, with a whopping Rs 554 crore business for the Hindi version alone. And that is how, in two fell swoops, Khan put an end to the naysayers who had pronounced the end of the Shah Rukh Khan era after *Jab Harry Met Sejal* and *Zero*.

It wasn't easy though. Long branded as Bollywood's 'king of romance', Khan had to reinvent himself as an action hero for this grand comeback. That's not the most traditional trajectory for a Bollywood actor just a few years shy of 60. Khan, for a change, chose to go in with a twist. He was not your typical hero. Pathaan would be battered in fights, he would even need some rescuing at times, but ultimately, with a bloodied, muddied, black-eyed face, he would forebodingly de-